

Wildcat

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OCCUPATIONS — THE ANSWER TO REDUNDANCIES?

Over the last 18 months the Manchester area in particular has seen a spate of workers occupations against redundancies. Most recently there has been the 'sit-in' strike against the threatened sacking of 200 workers at Kay Metzwlars Mill in Marple, and the occupation at Barnes Flexible Packaging in Cheetham against the loss of 230 jobs. Both these instances have been preceded by two better known, long and bitter struggles involving occupations, one at Lawrence Scotts in Openshaw and another at Gardners in Salford. These struggles initially inspired many workers, in Manchester and throughout the country, to fight against redundancies, but neither can claim to have been victories. Some harsh lessons must be learnt if the tide of redundancies is to be stemmed.

Although Gardners eventually went back to work, it was only on short-time and with the loss of 300 jobs. Now they are facing a further 400 redundancies. The Lawrence Scott occupation was physically ended with

the help of 40 private thugs backed up by police. The workers have now accepted redundancy money and unemployment pay, although they are still picketing to prevent the removal of machinery.

WHAT WENT WRONG?

1. Although the workers in each case took the militant step of occupying the factory they for the most part sat tight, seeking solidarity from other workers only in the form of financial contributions.
2. What attempts were made to get other workers to take industrial action were made entirely through official union channels, instead of directly to workers involved and got little response.
3. Control of the strike was left largely in the hands of shop stewards instead of being run directly by mass meetings and an elected strike committee.

As a result the workers were effectively isolated and 'starved out' by the bosses and the unions.

In the case of Lawrence Scotts the Engineering Union actively worked against the strikers, by negotiating a defeat and then withdrawing recognition and strike pay when the workers rejected their crummy deal. Angry workers responded to this by occupying 'their' Union's head office - only to find the police called in by their Union bosses to try and shift them!

In the present economic situation, occupations are only useful if they are a base for organising to spread the struggle to other work places and the local community. The lessons are clear. Fellow Lawrence Scott workers in Norwich who didn't join their struggle earlier are now themselves faced with massive redundancies. Only UNITED STRUGGLE OUTSIDE THE CONTROL OF THE UNIONS offers any hope of a solution to the present crisis.

That kind of unity can also be the basis for a struggle against the whole system of profits and markets which continually wastes the energy and skills of people like those at Gardners and Lawrence Scotts.

COMMUNITY POLICING — BRUTALITY WITH A HUMAN FACE

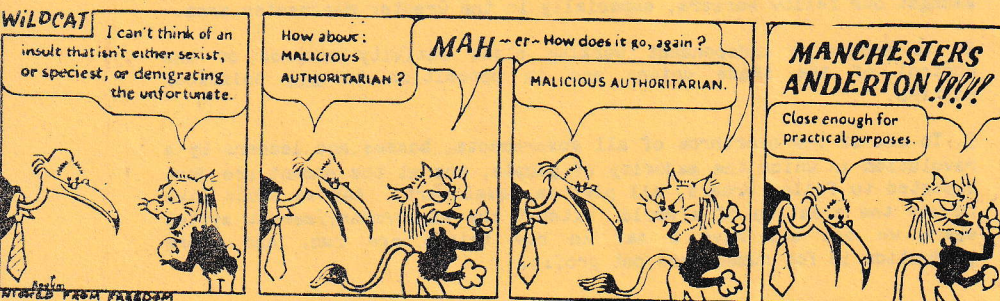
The riots in parts of Britain's cities this summer have meant that more people than usual have seen the reality of the police. Police vans driven at speed into crowds, killing at least one person, indiscriminate baton charges, beatings in police stations etc. This has led to calls that the police were 'out of control' and that we need 'democratic control of the police' or even 'community policing'. But in reality the police were not out of control. Their actions of those few nights had been planned for years. Their tactics were quite simply to clear the streets, to terrify the population back into their homes, and thus to 'preserve public order'. To imagine that the police would ever behave differently in a riot situation is ridiculous.

But a real debate is going on within the State as to the future of the British Police Force. Whether to

go for permanent riot squads, totally isolated from the community, or to attempt to form 'friendly' links with the community (bobbies on bicycles). The term community policing is deceptive; at first sight it would seem to mean that the community should police itself, but the meaning behind the phrase is to police the community with the co-operation of certain sections of it. Whenever a State gets into difficulties maintaining its authority it seeks to find people to act as intermediaries. This was the practice in the colonies where certain co-operative people were elevated to high positions since they knew the people better and the State could exercise power more effectively through them. That is the reality behind the calls from the 'liberal' wing of the State for democratic control of the police. The aim is to find 'Uncle Toms' within the community to act as intermediaries, feeding information to the police

and legitimising their presence. The hope is that this will enable the police to be more selective in their use of terror, and not to alienate any more people than they have to. The aim is to "win the hearts and minds" of the community rather than "bomb them back to the Stone Age" to use terms which accompanied the same debate in Vietnam. That is also what lies behind the Manchester police taking kids from the inner-city areas to the Lake District.

But revolutionaries have no place in this debate, it is not for us to advise the State as to which are the most effective means of repression. Our actions should be towards supporting the riots, not in order to divert them into more 'acceptable' forms of struggle, but to try and extend the struggle into a more thorough attack on the existing social structures. The main defect of the riots was not that they attacked the police and looted, but that they only attacked the police and looted. More, much more, is needed before we finally bury this decaying system.



TYPISTS' REBELLION

In the office hierarchy, typists, almost entirely women workers, are at the bottom. Most are badly paid with few prospects for 'career' advancement, even though most office routines would collapse without them.

Despite the poor pay of these workers, they have, along with other poorly paid clerical workers been subject to rationalisations and redundancies as a result of the introduction of word processors and other new technology.

Against this background and in the face of years of neglect from national union negotiators, typists in many local authorities have been organising to get regrading of their jobs and increases in pay. With little experience and confronted with prejudices displayed by many of

their fellow (especially male) workers they have begun to flex their industrial muscle.

Typists working for Liverpool City Council have gone on strike and disrupted Council meetings. Manchester City Council's typists have waged a lengthy 'work to rule', but with minimal support from other Council workers and against the background of a cosy relationship between local union officials and the Labour administration they eventually decided against strike action by a narrow majority.

This undoubtedly represents a major setback for all Local Authority typists, since the decision to strike alongside the Liverpool workers could

have begun a national movement, capable of defeating the employers in a way that local struggles could not. Certainly employers (Labour, Liberal, and Conservative) were aware of this potential and worked hard together with the unions to keep the different groups of typists and other workers isolated. This hasn't been entirely successful in Liverpool where there have been spontaneous walk-outs by other Council workers facing suspension for refusing to 'blackleg'. The situation in Manchester isn't so good, but there is still a great deal of anger amongst typists which could easily re-surface. Hopefully the few informal contacts made amongst typists outside the official union machinery can be expanded and a real effort made to bring about united action against the divisive policies of employers.

LABOUR PAINS

This year's Labour Party conference has revealed just now divided the Party is, and the depth of the crisis it is in. Healey may have won the deputy leadership, but the wrangling goes on. Despite their obvious differences there's one thing Healey and Benn (and the rest of the Labour Party) have in common: they both support capitalism. Healey wants a middle of the road version with the state intervening in the economy only where it seems necessary (private bosses can be more 'efficient' than State ones). Benn wants to nationalise everything in sight so there's one big boss - the Government. But neither of them really challenge the system of profits and markets we live in the world over.

To be sure Benn talks more and more of "socialism", and of changing the social and economic system (as if Britain could somehow, independently of the rest of the world, get rid of capitalism!). But he's playing on the desperation produced by the economic crisis. As more and more people see that capitalism as a social and economic system is cracking up, he can see what appeal "socialist" talk will have - and it is just talk. We all know what Labour governments have been like in the past: just as bad as the Tories! Under the last Labour government we had the "Social Contract" - the fastest fall in living standards ever - and unemployment doubled. The "Tory dole queue" may all too soon be another Labour dole queue. And we all know the record Labour has for breaking election promises. Take the issue of defence. Many people who otherwise don't like the Labour Party are supporting it because it says it will promote peace, unlike the obviously warmongering Tories. But in 1964 a Labour government was elected on a promise of nuclear disarmament - and they never carried it out. And the last Labour government was the one that started the present modernisation programme - including Cruise missiles and Trident submarines.

It's not a question of the sincerity of Labour's supporters - it's that when a Labour government

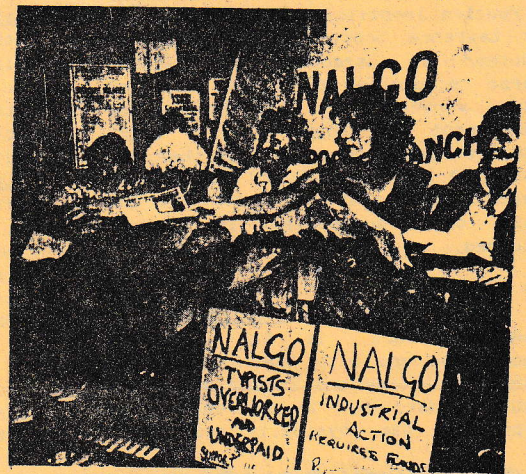
gets into power they find, just like every other government, that they have to obey the necessities of profit and the world economy.

The truth is that no government (Labour, Liberal, SDP, or Tory) can do anything to solve the economic crisis or to avert the threat of world war. Benn is correct in seeing that capitalism is now the greatest threat to the human race. But we can't leave it up to him or a future Labour government to do the changing for us; the only people who can finish off this dying system and build a future for us and our children are ourselves.

BARNES DEAL

The majority of workers who have been on strike at Barnes Flexible Packaging have accepted a poor redundancy deal worked out by their Union negotiators in SOGAT whilst the remaining 36 NGA members were still occupying the factory. This is another example of the way in which union divisions amongst workers has enabled discussions on strike tactics and negotiations to be removed from the workers involved and left in the hands of 'professional' Union men with little stomach for fighting the employers. Unlike the Unions in other recent disputes an effort was made to spread the dispute to other workers in the same group of companies, at least in a small way, and this doubtless convinced many Barnes workers that they could leave things in the Unions hands but experience has shown that this was little more than a smokescreen.

DEMO AT TUC



Striking Liverpool typists at last month's Trades Union Congress.

CONTACT

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objectives

1. To report on, analyse and seek solidarity for important struggles amongst our fellow workers, especially in the Greater Manchester area.
2. To encourage independent working class activity outside of the control of the trade unions and in opposition to all political parties.
3. To aim at the overthrow of all governments, bosses and leaders by a revolution in which the majority of people, who at the moment are just expected to follow orders, all play an equal part. And we would like to see the creation of a world, without the wages/money/market system where we can all have a say in how things are run, and where production is for human need not profit.